This, and many other such anomalies, were pointed out to the MoD, but most of them have remained unresolved, even more than a decade later. This has forced officers and other ranks too, to approach the courts for redress, thus giving the impression that either the Army does not care or that we are fighting against our own personnel. Many of these issues would get resolved much faster if there were to be cross-staffing in the MOD, with the Secretary, Department of Ex-Servicemen Welfare, being a uniformed person.

Higher Defence Organization (HDO)

The crisis in Ladakh highlighted the need for a more robust HDO to handle various crises. This HDO has to be beyond the MoD but short of the CCS. The CSG is a good model to work upon, which proved its worth during the Ladakh crisis, the only lacunae being that the other two Service Chiefs were not part of the CSG. The CSG can easily be renamed as the Security Studies Group, co-chaired by the RM and EAM, and including all three Chiefs. The CDS then can become a permanent member of the CCS. Moreover, a serving two-star-rank officer having good tri-service experience must be part of the PMO.

The creation of the Department of Military Affairs (DMA) is a step in the right direction, but much more reform is required. The first is to have cross-postings of officials in the two verticals of the MoD. While the DMA has civilian staff at the level of Joint Secretaries and Directors, the Department of Defence (DoD) vertical does not have any uniformed personnel. This anomaly needs to be rectified. Furthermore, the Secretary, DMA, wears the additional hats of CDS as well as permanent Chairman of the Chiefs of Staff Committee. These

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